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JAGMOHAN DALMIYA,
President, CAB



It is important to hold matches and we will do it despite the odds."

Those odds are plenty. Eden Gardens looks like a bomb site, parts of its famous concrete stands brought down. The night of the India versus Sri Lanka ODI last December made for a surreal sight with a strange state of affairs. The public couldn't buy tickets as there weren't any free seats after

the members of the CAB were handed out complimentary passes. This time, with a section of construction complete, around 9,000 tickets will be sold and 35,000 passes will be given to the members. Even then the Eden Gardens' total figure of 45,000 is far less than the famous one lakh.

That behemoth number may actually never be seen at the Eden again. With the 2011 World Cup its biggest event in years and spectator facilities causing more of a noise in the news, the 76-year-old ground is going in for a facelift. The uncomfortable 15-inch concrete seats that numbed many a Kolkata behind are to be replaced by comfortable 18-inch bucket seats, the spectator's staple all over the ground.

The CAB promises easy access to drinking water and toilet facilities for spectators. To avoid its floodlights blacking out, Dalmiya says the CAB wants to bring in back-up generators.

Many believe these plans are not the tip of an iceberg, but a master plan for the Eden Gardens of tomorrow. Though not yet finalised, there may also be a Lord's style cricket museum and a heritage structure for the National Cricket Club. It may still take

a few more months for the details to take shape but CAB insiders are confident that the historic ground will see dramatic changes. With just about a year in hand, will the time be enough? Dalmiya is confident it will.

The return of Eden Gardens to Indian cricket's centrestage even when it looks far from its best (much like the Indian team) can also be interpreted as Dalmiya's retunnelling into the corridors of power. However, the former BCCI and International Cricket Council chief remains non-committal. There are even whispers of a patch-up between Modi and Dalmiya, triggered by Modi's visit to Kolkata for a "chat" with the city's best known sports official. Dalmiya's response is a stern frown. "I don't think that is possible."

The cold shoulder given by the BCCI to the Eden Gardens for more than two seasons was seen as a mere reflection of the distance put by the new regime to the old fox. But does giving it more attention and a slightly busier calendar mean that relations are being mended and the temperature is slightly warmer now? Dalmiya says, "The rift is not over, but a solution is in sight. Things are more balanced now."

So here we are again. The Indian team in turmoil with its informal 'world championship of cricket' on the mat again, and the return to Eden. After the Nagpur innings defeat, Sunil Gavaskar spoke about the Kolkata Test on television and said, "All is going to come down to the pitch."

CAB's curator Prabir Mukherjee is stern. There has been no official instruction from the BCCI to change the nature of the pitch. "And even if there was," he says, "I really can't do that overnight. And I will not do it also. India can become the best team in the world on merit only, we don't need to cheat."

In 2005, Mukherjee said he had famously said no to shaving off the grass from the pitch even when asked by the Indian team management before a one day international. India lost that match—to South Africa. Once again, India returns to Eden in search of magic. So what if paradise only holds half its aura? ■